

WILLGABBTHISISAFRICAEDIT

And my guest this week is Will Gabb from This Is Africa Travel, a part of the Toucan Travel Group. And Will, welcome to the program. Thank you very much, Geoff.

Now, Will, tell us about This Is Africa. It's a fantastic way to see a very interesting place. Yeah, This Is Africa is a African wholesaler specializing in anything and everything to do with Eastern Southern Africa, from our kind of budget, overland camping expeditions, right up to our ultra high-end fly-in, fly-out, and everything in between.

So whether or not you want to have some beach time in the Maldives or Zanzibar, or you want to climb Kilimanjaro, or you just want to go and hit up some of the best wildlife left on the planet, we can source it for you, either our tailor-made packages or the full tailor-made experience. Anything and everything to do with Eastern Southern. And tell us about some of your experiences, because you've obviously done all this yourself, and some of the highlights for you.

I used to be a overland tour leader for Toucan Travel, actually, for a few years, running that big Nairobi to Cape Town trips. The highlights is obviously the wildlife is number one, the best wildlife on the planet, hands down, and can be found throughout Eastern Southern Africa. There are probably hundreds of different national parks, so not enough time to go into them now.

To go gorilla trekking, seeing the last mountain gorillas left in the wild is probably the single best thing you can do in Africa. Not cheap anymore, a permit is about 700 US dollars, but worth every single dollar. The scenery and the people on top of that.

So most people will go to Africa initially to go on safari, see the wildlife. The scenery from desert to rainforest to mountains blows people away. And Africa unfairly has a poor reputation for security.

That's true in places, but not the areas, obviously, that you wanna go to. And the people are absolutely lovely. The governments are the ones that have held that entire continent back, but the people are incredibly friendly.

You go and visit Maasai tribes and Himba warrior tribes down the south in Southern Namibia, that type of thing. It's an absolutely beautiful continent that more people should travel to. Now, I saw a little thing last night on TV about the Maasai, actually, and they do this thing where they walk up to lions and intimidate them and take their food.

That is just absolutely incredible, the bravery of these guys. So to become a Maasai warrior back in the day, every Maasai had to kill his own lion. And obviously they've had to stop doing that because otherwise there would be no lions left.

But the lions have been hunted for centuries by the Maasai, and they are terrified of them. And

literally, that's why a lot of our campsite guards are all Maasai warriors, because they have their red, obviously, kind of tartan blankets. The lions recognize that color, and they are off.

All the wildlife is now heavily protected, and the Maasai obviously are now earning a living as safari guides and their security, and particularly in the Maasai Mara and the Serengeti up in East Africa, which is where their tribal kind of territory is. And we have to understand that it really is a dog-eat-dog world in parts of Africa. This is jungle territory, and the thing is that we have to go by their ways as well.

We can't impose our views on them to a certain extent. Africa, obviously they've got abject poverty across the whole continent. It's very much a third world destination.

But I do believe that the tourist money that we bring, you know, Africa can be an expensive destination. Some of the most beautiful lodges that you'll ever stay in can be found across East and Southern Africa. The tourist dollar that that provides to the countries is obviously incredibly valuable to them, and it means that they're gonna protect this wildlife.

It needs to have a value put on it, like the gorilla permits thing, \$700. There's only 700 mountain gorillas left on the planet. They're slowly increasing in number, but that is only because the local governments have realized that it's a big U.S. dollar foreign currency earner for them, and I'm perfectly happy with that as long as they, you know, protect these last true wilderness areas left on the planet.

And there's a great way of seeing Africa where you can go in these arcturus tents, which they set up for you, which is terrific. Look, there's many options in Africa from your very unglamping camping on our big overland trucks, which is a trip that I used to run for a few years, which are very much grouped on a big Mercedes-Benz truck driving across Africa, putting up your own tent, right up to the fly-in, fly-out, glamping kind of out of Africa experience, private butlers where you're in a tent, but you can't really describe it as a tent because it's got four rooms to it, en-suite, hardwood floors, your own private butler, that type of thing. But you obviously deserve very much a price discrepancy between the two types of camping.

You don't have to spend a fortune in Africa if you don't want to camp. You know, there are three and four star lodges. You don't have to go for the ultra, ultra high end, you know, which is your classic honeymoon products, that type of thing.

There is something for everybody in Africa as far as, you know, budgets and itineraries are concerned, you know, and we're more than happy to, you know, chat with anybody. We do anything to do with the whole of Eastern Southern, from rail journeys to mountain climbing to beach trips to the classic safari. And Will Gabb from This Is Africa, how can people find out more online? So we've got a website, obviously, online, This Is Africa, or come and chat to us.

Well, our head office is in Sydney, but we've got, obviously, staff on the road around all the

Australian states. We're opening an office down in Johannesburg to source a lot of our Southern African bookings over there. But give us a call and we're more than happy to help.

And all of our reps and sales staff in the office have all lived and worked in Africa extensively. Give us a call and we'll tell you what we think you should be doing to suit your timescales and budgets. And we'll go from that.

Terrific. So it's thisisafrica.com, they can find you? Yes, certainly is. Or just give us a call or get all our details online.

And more than happy to help with any African inquiry. Well, Gabb, thank you very much for being part of the program this week. You're welcome.

Have a good day, Jeff.